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THE **HEART** OF HOSPITALITY

GREAT HOTEL and
RESTAURANT LEADERS
SHARE THEIR SECRETS

**"The only
book of its kind:**

A spectacularly useful,
intelligent, and wry look at
what determines success
in the hospitality
industry."

MICAH SOLOMON

FOREWORD BY HERVE HUMLER

President and COO

THE RITZ-CARLTON HOTEL COMPANY

Advance Praise for *The Heart of Hospitality*

Please enjoy this professional courtesy copy of *The Heart of Hospitality*. Please contact me directly with book questions (publicity, ordering, etc.) or professional questions (to engage me as a consultant, keynote speaker, trainer, or training designer).



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Micah

“Sooner or later, we’re all in the hospitality business. I bet you’ll find that chapter 8 alone is worth the cost of the book.”

—**Seth Godin**

Author of *What to Do When It’s Your Turn*

“At Virgin Hotels, we are building a new hotel experience—something that can only be done by learning lessons from the greats of our industry and understanding the needs and wants of today’s consumers. In *The Heart of Hospitality*, Micah Solomon—one of the true thought leaders of the customer experience—has gathered unparalleled hospitality wisdom and distilled it in an incredibly readable and useful format. We were delighted to be part of this project and recommend it to any company or individual looking to grow within our industry.”

—**Raul Leal**

CEO, Virgin Hotels

“A spectacularly useful, intelligent, and wry look at what determines success in the hospitality industry.”

—**Herve Humler**

President and COO, The Ritz Carlton Hotel Company

“In this groundbreaking new book, Micah Solomon manages to distill the wisdom of some of America’s most enlightened hospitality professionals. He combines the power of their insights with his own refreshing point of view in a compelling narrative style that is concise and to the point. *The Heart of Hospitality* illustrates that ultimately it is the human connection that builds and sustains guest loyalty. This is an inspirational and useful book for anyone interested in customer satisfaction. Is there anyone who isn’t?”

—**Patrick O’Connell**

Chef/Proprietor, The Inn at Little Washington

“An incredibly valuable look at the hospitality industry, hospitality management, and how to succeed with today’s (and tomorrow’s) guests.”

—Sara Kearney

Vice President, Hyatt Hotels Corporation

“It’s ironic, but many people and organizations in our industry fail because they lack knowledge and insight for how to provide true hospitality, how to truly care for the guest. That’s why *The Heart of Hospitality* is so important. It steps in to fill this gap. And it fills it with knowledge from the very best: hospitality icons Isadore Sharp, founder and chairman of Four Seasons Hotels and Resorts; Herve Humler, president and COO of The Ritz-Carlton Hotel Company; Danny Meyer, president and CEO of Union Square Hospitality Group, and so many more. Micah Solomon has interviewed the key executives from hospitality’s best, including those from The Broadmoor and The Inn at Little Washington, Montage, Fairmont, EDITION, and Virgin Hotels and has merged their insights with his own as one of the best and best-known customer service experts himself.

Their collective insight focuses on all the key ingredients to deliver an exceptional guest experience—hiring the right people, developing the necessary internal systems and hospitality standards, creating the proper service culture, defining steps for service recovery and visualizing anticipatory service, as well as offering fascinating and essential discussions on how technology has and will change the guest experience.

—Bill Quiseng,

Hospitality-industry GM

(Radisson, Renaissance, Autograph Collection)

“Micah Solomon has gathered all of the great hospitality industry heroes, hotel management practitioners and great restaurateurs together and pulled crucial hospitality management and business insights out of them. This is transformational to the reader who wants to thrive in the challenging world of hospitality and hospitality management.”

—Rupesh Patel

President and CEO, 3Hospitality

THE **HEART** OF **HOSPITALITY**

**Great Hotel and
Restaurant Leaders
Share Their Secrets**

MICAH SOLOMON



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(click to watch author's video)



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Foreword

There have been volumes written—complete curricula, in fact—that cover the technical, nuts-and-bolts, RevPAR [revenue per available room] side of the hospitality industry. But what about the soul, the heart of what makes great hospitality? How do you create (and sustain) a level of service so memorable that it becomes a defining part of your brand and an unbeatable competitive advantage?

You'll find many of the answers in the book you now hold in your hands, *The Heart of Hospitality*. Micah Solomon has put together the only book of its kind: a spectacularly useful, intelligent, and wry look at what determines success in the hospitality industry, packing it throughout with his own insights and the insights of an extraordinary roster of great leaders and practitioners from our industry today.

Micah is one of today's preeminent thought leaders on where hospitality, customer service, and customers themselves are heading. As an avid reader of his earlier works, I was honored by the invitation to help bring this volume to life with access to our General Managers, the Ladies and Gentlemen who helm our Leadership Center, our technology initiatives, our branding and marketing efforts, and behind-the-scenes looks at the practices that make our Ritz-Carlton hotels and resorts premier destinations.

The other industry leaders who have contributed their perspectives to *The Heart of Hospitality* notably include, in lodging, Steve Bartolin at The Broadmoor Hotel, Isadore Sharp at Four Seasons Hotels and Resorts, Mark Harmon at Auberge Resorts, Raul Leal at Virgin Hotels, Mark Hoplamazian and his Hyatt brands, Jennifer Fox at Fairmont,

and more. On the culinary side of the equation, you will find insights from notable restaurateurs and others in the world of F&B [food and beverage], including Danny Meyer, Eric Ripert, Tom Colicchio, Patrick O’Connell, Traci Des Jardins, Stephen Starr, and others.

Our industry is both timeless and evolving very rapidly. To achieve and sustain success in hospitality, we must keep pace with changing guests and their changing expectations. Micah explains (at length in chapter 9 as well as throughout the book) what’s involved in making the changes that are necessary to keep up. His predictions and research about how travelers—travelers of all ages and millennials in particular—are changing the world of hospitality are absolutely spot-on and are important to take to heart.

My greatest joy and thrill in life is helping others succeed. I truly believe that *The Heart of Hospitality* will be instrumental in boosting your outcomes in our exciting industry. Wherever you are in your journey within the hospitality industry, the insights and lessons inside are essential.

Read it, earmark it, highlight it, *learn it*.

You will be well served.

—HERVE HUMLER

President and COO

The Ritz-Carlton Hotel Company, LLC



Introduction

Steve Jobs was determined (as only Steve could be) to build a customer service experience at the Apple Stores that would rival the best customer service to be found anywhere, in any industry. So, before opening a single Apple Store to the public, he made his rounds among the employees at Apple headquarters in Cupertino, asking a single question, over and over: “What’s the best experience you’ve ever had as a customer?” Nearly every answer he got back, from nearly every employee, was similar, and, no, they weren’t tales of superlative experiences as customers at CompUSA (RIP), Circuit City (ditto), or any of the other electronics retailers against which the Apple Stores would soon be competing.

The answer Steve kept hearing from his Apple employees was that the best customer experiences in the world were taking place at Ritz-Carlton hotels, Four Seasons resorts, and other exemplars of the hospitality industry. These responses convinced Jobs to insist that those involved in the creation of the Apple Stores study, benchmark, and emulate the hospitality industry. The impact of this decision is most visible in Apple Stores’ “Genius Bar” (a direct tribute to a hotel concierge area) but goes much deeper, affecting everything from Apple Store hiring practices to how employees greet customers and bid them farewell.

Steve Jobs’ admiration for the hospitality industry was right on target. There truly is no other type of business that is better at transforming the essentials of everyday life—a room, a bed, a sink, a toilet, a meal—into an experience that is warm, comforting, memorable, and perhaps even magical.

The opportunity you’ll find within these pages is the chance to learn how this hospitality industry magic is created and sustained. You’ll learn

directly from the very best in the business: the CEOs, GMs, chefs, and other visionaries at the greatest hospitality companies in the world. I've packed the pages of this book with their perspectives on the culture, hiring, training, systems, and philosophical framework necessary to bring extraordinary hospitality to life, day after day and night after night in the face of changing customer fashions and expectations.

This is important, powerful stuff. It's drawn from exclusive interviews I've made over the course of many months specifically for this book. (At the end of this book, you'll find a listing of everyone who contributed the interviews on which this book is based.) I also made site visits to many of the great and innovative hotels, resorts, and restaurants in the industry. I've shaped and rounded out this material based on my own insights as a consultant, speaker, and business leader working both inside and outside the hospitality industry. And I've closed out every chapter with a summary titled **"And Your Point Is?"** It's filled with key points in an abbreviated format that's intended to serve a similar purpose as the Cliffs Notes® some of us depended on in school.

So, I hope you enjoy learning from the best of the best—the greatest leaders and professionals at the best lodging and food service organizations in the world.



A bit about me: I work across a wide range of industries as a customer service consultant, keynote speaker, and trainer. I have a long background in assisting companies to become successful by creating and maintaining superior customer service and an exemplary customer experience. (If you'd like the examples or lessons in this book to be made specific to you or your organization, please let me know by emailing me at micah@micahsolomon.com or calling me directly at (484)343-5881. In keeping with a customer service best practice, I answer my own phone.)





1

The Last Customer on Earth

“The only metric a guest cares about is this: one to one. That one guest in front of one associate. Will that associate take care of me? And **does** that associate care about me?”*

—Hospitality professional BILL QUISENG

ut of nowhere, a dog bounds up to the reception desk of the Hyatt House hotel in suburban Virginia, clearly on a mission. The front desk agent leans over and tosses a rolled newspaper into the dog’s waiting mouth. With this stage of his mission accomplished, the dog walks away with his tail wagging, and the agent goes back to work processing paperwork for the next guest.

A Colleague and a Collie

Has Hyatt House resorted to employing bell staff of the four-legged variety? Actually, this dog is a guest of sorts. “His owner had just sold her home after 40 years of living there and, like many of our guests at Hyatt House, is in a bit of limbo before moving into her first apartment space as an empty-nester,” explains Hyatt senior vice president Sara Kearney. “My colleague at the front desk [at this point in the interview I had to confirm that Kearney had said “colleague,” not “collie”] has been trying to help

* All quotations in this book, including this one, are taken from interviews conducted for this book by Micah Solomon, unless indicated otherwise. A complete list of those who contributed interviews is on page 197.

this guest maintain some semblance of her routine from her previous life. So each morning her dog pads down the hall to the front desk, gets the newspaper just like he did when they lived at home, and carries it back to the guest room where his master awaits.”

Hospitality guests are by definition dislocated. They’re not eating at home, not sleeping at home—they’re *away*. Though this displacement is no doubt voluntary at a resort location or a trip to a restaurant, at an extended-stay property like Hyatt House (the economically priced, extended-stay hotel brand that Hyatt carved out of its AmeriSuites acquisition), the dislocation is likely to be the result of an awkward and possibly painful situation. Guests here include the recently divorced, those enduring job assignments away from their families, and those whose houses have sold before they’ve settled on a new one. These are situations where the psychological realities of a guest’s life can be weighing heavily on their perception of the goods and services you’re providing. And it’s a situation where true service—hospitality—can shine.

But it can’t shine when delivered in an assembly-line fashion. It needs to be focused on one guest at a time. What Hyatt House was doing for this guest was specific to her, and, therefore, meaningful.

That’s the crux of the matter—the opportunity and challenge that we’ll be exploring in this chapter. Treating a guest as your *only* guest, focusing on what your guest needs beyond a secure lock on the door, an appropriate room rate, a meal *sans* salmonella, and so forth, is where you’ll find the opportunity to distinguish yourself in hospitality—to build an advantage that competitors will find harder to knock off than the momentary advantages of perks like two-for-one desserts.

It’s All About That Focus

Let’s leave Hyatt House and travel to what’s considered one of the most extraordinary restaurants and small hotels in the United States. We’ll still be in Virginia, but are otherwise far afield. We’re going to have dinner at

Patrick O'Connell's legendary restaurant called The Inn at Little Washington, a double Five Star (per Forbes), double Five Diamond (per AAA) restaurant and inn in the rural county of Rappahannock, home to only 7,000 full-time human residents as well as a significant number of sheep, cattle, and, for some obscure reason, ostriches.

In addition to all the other superlatives that have been voiced about The Inn at Little Washington ("Best Restaurant in America," "Most Beautiful Kitchen in the World," and on and on), here's one more that fits: "Situated in the ultimate of inconvenient locations." One time, in fact, a friend of mine who was peeved at me for picking such an out-of-the-way location for our get-together, crankily described the route he was required to travel. He said, "*First*, I had to drive to the middle of nowhere. *Then*, I had to drive *another* thirty minutes to get here."

Yet food- and experience-obsessed guests have made this beautiful and inconvenient spot a pilgrimage site. Guests have included kings, queens, and presidents (actual presidents and those of the mere popularly-elected variety—Al Gore and then-wife Tipper had their anniversary dinner at The Inn every year) as well as true gourmets without rank or status have saved their money for months, years, or a decade to be able to experience the food and hospitality of the inn for a night.

Of course, there are a lot of different pieces that go into creating the double Five Star (twenty-four years straight with the Forbes/Mobil Travel Guide) double Five Diamond (twenty-five years straight with AAA) gem that is The Inn at Little Washington: The kitchen. The training. The décor by London stage designer Joyce Evans. Exclusive farm and sourcing resources. The gentle comedy of Faira, the cow on wheels that brings the cheese course around the dining room, her tableside arrival announced by the ringing tones of her cowbell. And, of course, Chef O'Connell himself, famously dubbed "the Pope of American Cuisine" by the late, leading vineyard operator Robert Mondavi. But the one facet that O'Connell tells me has to shine beyond all others to make the entire operation succeed is *focus*—a complete focus on the guest, one person at a time.

The heart of hospitality, for me, is the ability to focus completely and totally on one person, even if only for a matter of seconds, yet long enough that you've got a clear connection, a channel between the two of you. It's the ability to focus so intently on a guest that the rest of the world ceases to exist. It might sound, as I tell you this, that this type of focus takes a lot of time, but it doesn't; it just requires your full and complete attention at a given moment. You have to develop the discipline of momentarily blotting out the rest of the world. Believe me: your guest will know immediately when you've succeeded.

As an antecedent to his approach, O'Connell gives a nod to "the geishas in Japan who can make a patron feel, for the time they are together, like the most important person in the world. In today's world, if you think about it, we're often so fractured and distracted that we barely even make eye contact with people. Now, if you have a *puppy*, everybody's going to make eye contact with the little puppy and light up and be intrigued, but when encountering another human being, sometimes we have a tendency, from shyness, weariness, who knows, to do the opposite and blot them out. But what could possibly be more important than the person standing in front of you?"

O'Connell offered me a recent example of his approach to connecting with guests:

A woman recently ate in our dining room by herself, reading her book through the course of the meal. I asked my staff, "Did you interact with her?" They told me, "We tried, of course, but she's somewhat reserved and hasn't given us much information to work with." Because we were at a bit of a loss for how to make a connection, at the end of the meal her waiter invited her back to the kitchen to visit with us. She came in, still carrying her book. As it turned out, I had read the same book, so I was able to make a comment or two about it. Immediately, she opened up and said that she was there celebrating her husband's birthday. He had died the year before at

a very young age, and it [The Inn at Little Washington] was always a place they had planned to come together, so she was making the visit herself in his memory. I thought to myself: "Imagine if she had come all the way out here and not had an opportunity to share that information!" Being able to do so made it much more of a complete experience for her.

Customers are always giving you cues that are specific to that customer, and you have to be paying attention, every single time. Customers want you to be a "participant observer," someone who will share the experience with them. They want someone else to know the significance of the experience. They're often looking for someone with whom they can faithfully share information, and if they ever sense that you're uninterested or too busy, they won't.

Chef O'Connell has been in the business for decades—ever since 1978 when O'Connell opened his fledgling inn on the location of a former garage. Yet he and his staff still put the concept of single-guest focus into practice every day. That O'Connell has managed to *sustain* this commitment is extremely rare, as I can professionally attest.

Frequently, I'm brought in as a consultant when things are going inexplicably south at a previously thriving company in hospitality or another service-intensive field. When I start advising in this later period of stalled or negative growth, I'll pore through records and relics from the early, more auspicious days, looking for clues to what has since changed. Invariably, I'll find that in those early days, the level of detail the business kept on each customer, the number of customer follow-ups and the care taken with each one, was at a level that was impressive, even *epic*, as my kids would say.

Unfortunately, the focus and attentiveness that's common when a business has only a few customers tends to slide when those customer numbers multiply. You stop keeping, or at least stop referring back to, detailed notes on the likes and dislikes of every guest. Employees stop signing their thank-you notes by hand. Managers hide in their offices



rather than coming out to greet arriving customers. The bean counters get rid of Jackie and Joanne, your quirkily charismatic veteran telephone operators whom the guests all adored, and replace them with a lower paid rookie, or even an auto-attendant “voice jail” system.

Is such slippage of standards inevitable? Not if you stick to your guns. Here’s how I’d summarize the attitude of the great hoteliers, restaurateurs, and other hospitality professionals whose inspiration fills these pages: *If we did it for our first guest, we’ll find a way to keep doing it for our millionth*, without rushing or cutting corners, without doing anything that would make that guest feel any less than fully valued in our eyes.

Don’t Stop Believin’

The secret, in other words, is to never stop believing in the importance of the individual guest and the individual guest interaction, no matter how many guests your organization has grown to serve. Don’t ever fall into the trap of thinking that there is an infinite supply of guests out there for the taking, if only your marketing and sales departments would do their jobs. The hospitality greets instead tell themselves there’s just one guest, the one they’re facing *right now*.

The BUBL Method

If you don’t mind leaving pastoral Virginia for the glamor of Midtown Manhattan, let’s head to The Ritz-Carlton New York, Central Park, specifically to the hotel’s Club Level, where guests enjoy four daily food presentations and the service of a dedicated concierge and a team of attendants. I’ve brought you here not to enjoy the quintillion-dollar views of the park but to look at how the club environment in a great hotel offers a setting where hospitality professionals are called on to provide service in an unusually pure, distilled fashion. What the Ladies and Gentlemen (as employees proudly refer to themselves here at The Ritz-Carlton) do in a Club Level lounge is more free-form, less dependent on a specific,

predictable routine than what you'll find in traditional lodging or F&B (food and beverage). Employees here aren't serving carefully timed courses that need to arrive concurrently or consecutively in correct succession. They're not checking in guests at a peak entry period. Instead, they're at their guests' service throughout the day in whatever capacity may be useful, a loosely defined role whose success hinges on whether they manage to provide that service in a way that will be appreciated, rather than coming across as an interruption.

So as I hunch over my laptop in The Ritz-Carlton Club Level lounge working on this very chapter, at first it's what *doesn't* happen that is so impressive. The well-dressed, smiling club attendant *doesn't* come over to ask me if I want my coffee warmed up. Does this mean she's being inattentive? Quite the opposite. She sees that I am intently hammering out these very sentences and that it's a bad time to ask me anything. She remains ever observant, however, and is back and ready to serve as soon as I end the paragraph and lean back in my chair to ponder my next linguistic move.

This level of attentiveness, of empathetic and intuitive service, is phenomenal. But how do you transfer it to your own organization? To provide similarly skilled and nuanced service requires teaching your employees to pay attention to everything that is happening at the periphery of their senses and of their emotional awareness, what The Ritz-Carlton calls the principle of "Radar On—Antenna Up."

In addition, person-on-person service benefits from using a system, a framework that I've codified as the BUBL (pronounced "bubble") method. The awareness and behaviors represented in the BUBL acronym will assist you in interacting with guests in an effective and nuanced way.¹ The basis of BUBL, and the reason for the name, is the concept that each of your guests is surrounded by an individual, invisible, protective bubble. To be able to provide exceptional guest service, your team needs to be aware of this phenomenon and be conscious of the extent to which a guest's individual protective shell is open or closed at any particular

moment. Employees need to learn to recognize when it's okay to venture near and into the guest's protective bubble—the invisible “meditation chapel” within which the guest has expectations of solitude—and how to interact with the guest while that bubble is open. This is what the well-trained attendant at The Ritz-Carlton club lounge is doing when she discreetly avoids interrupting me mid-thought, and it's also what she's doing when she reverses course and provides me with service as soon as it's clear to her that she won't be interrupting.

Here are the steps of the BUBL method:

B: Begin immediately

U: Un-code the guest's messages and pacing

B: Break your schedule

L: Leave room for more interaction

Let's take these one by one.

- ***Begin immediately:*** The guest expects service to begin *the exact moment* that she comes into contact with the employee, so deciphering whether or not the guest actually considers meaningful contact to have been made is an important part of this step. For example, if a guest catches a server's eye, it may be merely accidental, but if the guest *holds* the server's gaze, it usually means that the guest's expecting to be offered assistance. (At busy times, the “begin immediately” step may need to be accomplished even if the employee's busy speaking with another customer. This requires learning to work with one customer while visually acknowledging the presence of a new arrival.)

- **Un-code:** (The word, I know, should be “Decode,” but that leaves us with an acronym of “BDBL,” which, though fun to try to pronounce, isn’t as memorable a mnemonic device as “BUBL.”) Decipher the messages the customer is giving you about her desired pacing of service, as well as her level of happiness or distress and other emotions, and adjust appropriately. (Such cues aren’t only detectable in person, by the way; they can be discerned on the phone, in online chat, via videoconferencing, etc.)
- **Break your schedule:** Your customer has let you into her bubble, her “meditation chapel,” for the moment. Drop what you’re doing and work on what she needs. True service can never be a slave to checking things off in a predetermined order. Attending properly to a customer means adhering to the *customer’s* schedule, not your own. This means, for example, waiting for a natural break in conversation before asking how a meal is tasting, rather than barging in when your guest’s in animated discourse or mid-bite into a juicy burger, just because she’s next in the order you had in mind as you started your rounds, and you don’t want to be delayed.
- **Leave room for more:** Is this really goodbye? Check before you conclude the interaction. It’s the service professional’s responsibility to ask if anything additional is needed and, if it isn’t, to graciously thank the customer before leaving her to her solitary sanctuary.

At the Center of the Customer’s Universe

The reason that such subtle aspects of service make a difference is because a guest wants to feel like they’re at the center of your world. And, as a service provider, there’s a lot of power in creating this impression. In a sense,

this will have to be an illusion that you're creating, because in reality you have—I'm making some assumptions here—a life of your own and more than one guest to support. But it's an extremely powerful, business-building illusion for the hospitality professional who can successfully pull it off.

Guests are already at the center of their own world, their own reality. All that matters to them are themselves and the people they care about, a category that probably only tangentially includes you. What they want from you as a service provider is not for you to grab center stage, but to reassure them that they hold center stage in your world as well as in their own.



PUTTING THE CUSTOMER AT THE CENTER IN A LIMITED-SERVICE SETTING

"When I drill down to why we get the great TripAdvisor scores and comments that we do," says Rupesh Patel, the owner of two midscale and economy properties in Daytona Beach, Florida, "it's never about our lobbies or our furnishings—it's about our employees and how central they made the guests feel in the hospitality experience. Even within the limitations of our budgets and staffing, we do many little things to make the guest feel at the center of our operation at our hotels, small touches that are directly focused on the goal of making every guest feel special: custom candy bars and water bottles with the guest's name on it, for example, as well as welcome letters that are customized for each guest. We're not The Ritz-Carlton, but we can treat our guests as if we were, within the context of our limited service environment. And it works."

The Red Bench Principle

Years ago, my wife and I took our daughter to her first half day of nursery school. On that fine New England morning, the young teacher collected our daughter from us outside the classroom, where we were sitting together on a red park bench. When the teacher brought our daughter back to us at noon, my wife and I were again sitting on that same red bench. It wasn't until two or three weeks later, as the routine continued, that we figured out that our daughter believed her parents were sitting on that red bench each day throughout the entire morning, awaiting her return. She didn't think this in a vague or metaphorical sense. She didn't kind of partially believe this. She *really* believed it.

I find this a good reminder of the nature of the relationship of a business to its guests. Because guests, even adults, generally share these dependent-child qualities, the last thing they're considering are the other obligations, interests, or activities of their service providers. Guests assume, until you prove them wrong (which would be a mistake) that your world revolves around them—all the way and all the time. And as a hospitality provider, you benefit from encouraging this impression rather than becoming resentful that a guest is presumptuous enough to be thinking this way. It's a credit to your business, and to your level of service, if they believe that you're truly all about them all the time.

So I'm going to suggest you throw out the clichéd image of “rolling out the red carpet” and replace it with “sitting on the red bench” as the ultimate in customer care. In other words, what's most important isn't so much to put on an all-star show for your guests (though that can be great as well) as it is to create and maintain the illusion that you are always there awaiting your guest, attending to her as if you had nothing else on your agenda that could possibly interfere. Pull this off and you're well on your way to guaranteeing yourself a guest for life.



The Last Customer on Earth

Maintaining and advocating this “treat each customer like the last customer on earth” attitude is one of the most important leadership responsibilities in a hospitality organization, one of the key weapons in the battle to avoid losing guests through your perceived indifference, and one of the attitudes and advocacies that every single hospitality leader represented in this book shines in promoting.

Hospitality professional Bill Quiseng: “Whether it’s acknowledging a guest as they’re walking down the hall or using a guest’s name at the hostess station, every interaction is a chance to make a guest feel cared for or to feel otherwise. And after every single interaction, the guest is making that determination of whether they were or weren’t cared for.” Restaurateur Danny Meyer, a legend of hospitality in New York (and now globally, thanks to the unparalleled success of his Shake Shack restaurant chain) shares the same sentiment, though he phrases it like a New Yorker: “Hospitality will not succeed unless the person on the receiving end knows all the way to the bottom of their *kishkes* [Yiddish for “guts”] that we’re on their side. The definition of hospitality for me is the degree to which [the guest] feels that we are on their side, we have their back, we are their agent.”

Meyer goes on to contrast this with the emotional disconnection customers often experience in the world of service:

Of course, [as consumers] we all have experiences that are the opposite of that, whether it’s getting a cup of coffee or shopping at a department store: The service, technically speaking, is quite good; the provider does all the things they’re supposed to do—yet it doesn’t feel great. Or when I’m on an airplane, I arrive alive and on time. I get the drink I asked for. But the problem is that I don’t get anything more. Not one person looks me in the eye while they’re wheeling the cart down the aisle; nobody smiles or makes me feel that I’m anything more than somebody occupying a seat.

Although these inattentive service interactions are, of course, not pleasant to experience as a customer, their frequency represents an upside for service professionals who are serious about one-guest-at-a-time service. The inattention of the rest of the business community represents an enormous competitive advantage; their affronts to the general customer population make the superior service of great hospitality organizations and professionals sparkle in contrast.



ERIC RIPERT: THE ESSENCE OF HOSPITALITY IS DIFFERENTIATION

"I didn't give a damn what the customer wanted when I was younger," confesses legendary chef Eric Ripert. "The only thing I cared about was my food—my vision as a chef. . . . I've since changed my ways," says Ripert, "because I realized that was the wrong way to go about things in a restaurant, and the wrong way to be as a person as well. It can never be just about the food."

Chef Ripert's commitment to food, of course, is unflagging. Le Bernardin, the New York institution where Ripert is Executive Chef, has retained a four star designation from *The New York Times* for an unparalleled thirty years and commands three stars from Michelin as well, in part because "We've upheld our particular reputation for food," as Ripert puts it modestly. Yet Le Bernardin, insists Ripert, is "in the hospitality business above all else."

Hospitality and Millennials

A temple of delicious hedonism like Le Bernardin is probably not what first comes to mind when you think of a millennial dining destination, but, says Ripert, "It's the millennials who have me excited now, who are stimulating my passion for hospitality. Being 100 percent committed to hospitality is important when you're

thinking about millennials and the experience that they want and insist on.” What millennials are looking for “is something that money almost cannot buy,” something that is more than “a piece of fish,” even an extraordinarily sourced and sauced fish. “It’s not going to work with the millennial customer to be inhospitable. They’re not going to take it if you come across as having an ego, an attitude, a lack of caring.”

Differentiated Hospitality

For guests of any age, millennial or otherwise, says Ripert, true hospitality has to be *differentiated* hospitality. At Le Bernardin, “It’s our responsibility to understand the need of the guest, to deliver an experience that’s individually crafted for each individual in the dining room.”

This means that Le Bernardin doesn’t necessarily fawn all over what other businesses might consider to be their “VIP” customers; the Le Bernardin approach to service is more subtle than that. “Le Bernardin is thought of as a destination, a place people come to have an out of the ordinary experience, but that’s too much of a generalization. We have regulars, people who come two, three times a week,” from their nearby offices or because they come to the neighborhood to conduct business. It would be jarring to these regulars if Le Bernardin made a production out of their every visit, so the restaurant makes a point of treating them in a manner that’s more as if they were members of a local club, whose repeated presence at the restaurant, while still appreciated, is an expected occurrence. “The local businessman doesn’t care about visiting the kitchen and taking pictures with the chef,” says Ripert, and the restaurant is scrupulous about not suggesting such activities to them. There’s also a contingent of guests whom Le Bernardin attracts who are wealthy (often international) travelers “who like to eat in this kind of restaurant but don’t like much interaction with the staff; we have to be careful to step back from them for this reason.”

Still, “The majority of our customers are the ones who come to have a celebration or an experience.” But even within this experience-seeking clientele,” there are key distinctions to be made. “There are

couples who come in for an experience, but who are so in love that they end up not seeing anything but each other. They don't want to be interrupted more than necessary, and they certainly don't want to come into the kitchen and take pictures." What they want, instead, "is a space for themselves, a bubble. Though they appreciate what we do in the restaurant, it's all about being together, the two of them."

Another contingent of bubble-enclosed customers are "the guests where the event they're celebrating, the birthday or the closing of a deal, is really the focus, not us." There are also, of course, many guests at the opposite spectrum, "customers who thrive on taking pictures with the chef, and on a lot of interaction with us." And then there are the foodies: "Le Bernardin is a place of celebration for foodies as well." Like others, the "foodies may want pictures with the chef and all of that, but they are most about the fish and the different flavors and the details of the menu."

If the restaurant gets all this right, concludes Ripert, "If we make them happy in the particular way they were looking to be made happy, they'll remember Le Bernardin and want to come back at their next opportunity. But to pull this off, we almost have to read the minds of the guest, to make sure we don't mistakenly end up providing the wrong kind of experience for them."

The How's and the Who's of Reading Minds

To allow the restaurant to read a room in such a subtle a manner and with so much at stake, Le Bernardin relies on dining room employees who have a long tenure (Ben Chekroun, Le Bernardin's dining room manager, has been in his position more than twenty years) and who are innately suited to the task of mindreading. Ripert says that "Many times the people I get for these positions have been recommended to me by other restaurants who notice this ability in them that we value here, people who will thrive working in our dining room."

Having said that, Ripert feels that mindreading "doesn't take a genius—it mostly takes *wanting* to do it. Even I," he continues with characteristic modesty, "although I'm a cook, I'm not front of the house, when I cross the dining room I can tell when I look at a table

who's a foodie, who's not a foodie, who's here for a business function, who cares about seeing the chef. You can see it in their behavior and in their eyes—the eyes that follow you wherever you go. You don't have to be a genius to see that. You just have to actually look, and you have to be focused on our shared goal at Le Bernadin, which, above all, is this: We want to provide *not* the experience we think the customer should have, but the experience the customer—the single customer in front of us—wants to have this evening.”

I can't wrap a bow around this chapter and allow us to move on without conceding something important: You *can't* always perform at a “last customer on Earth” level—although it's a level you can always aspire to. It is absolutely true that delivering this superior service to one guest at a time, without inconveniencing the rest of your guests who also want your assistance and attention, can be a significant challenge, involving investments in training, processes, and technology. In fact, you will not be able to execute a “last customer on Earth” approach to your satisfaction all the time. But if you don't actively, emphatically follow and believe in this approach, you'll end up compromising on the service you provide and not even realizing that you're doing this.

If you set out explicitly to do business the “last customer on Earth” way, while you may at times be forced to compromise your service ideal—because of limitations of time, staffing, technology, or other resources—when this happens, you'll feel the entire weight of the discrepancy. You'll know you're not living up to your ideal, and you will be motivated to work on the staffing, systems, technology, and processes that can bring you closer to the ideal.

“AND YOUR POINT IS”?

Key Principles from Chapter 1: The Last Customer on Earth

- ▶ Great hospitality must be focused on one guest at a time. For the moments that you are together, treat every guest as if she were the only customer in the world.
- ▶ For all of the best intentions that most of us start out with in our businesses, it's nearly inevitable that a high level of caring about the customer slips when customer numbers increase. And this loss directly sabotages the future growth of your company. The way to prevent too much slippage in standards is to be determined that you and your organization maintain the mindset that *“If we did it right for our first guest, we'll find a way to keep doing it for our millionth, one on one, without rushing or cutting corners.”*
- ▶ The BUBL method of serving customers: An important concept is that every guest is surrounded by an individual, invisible protective bubble. Your team needs to learn to recognize when it's okay to venture into the customer's protective bubble—and how to interact with the customer while that bubble is open. The BUBL method suggests the following:
 - B**egin immediately to have the interaction when the occasion arises.
 - U**n-code (decode) the guest's messages and pacing.
 - B**reak your schedule—be flexible and take advantage of opportunities for interaction.
 - L**eave room for additional interaction before ending the service interaction.





How the Digital Revolution Has Changed Your Customers

The only sense that is common, in the long run,
is the sense of change.⁴¹—E. B. WHITE

Today's customers think differently about customer service and the customer experience, and this is true both inside and outside of hospitality. Consumers today are buying (or deciding not to buy), raving about your customer service (or telling their friends to avoid you), enhancing (or depressing) your bottom line based on factors your business may have never considered.

It's important to get a fix on this, and quickly, because the changes that customers have already begun to clamor for are just a whisper compared to what's about to come. Every trend that affects your business subtly today will actively confront your company within a few years, as younger customers enter the marketplace and revolt against the archaic ways that you're still doing business.

The Arrival of the Millennial Generation

A key reason for the urgency of this message is demographic. Millennial customers, born between 1980 and 2000 (give or take), are the largest generation in United States and world history—even larger than the baby

boom at its height, and significantly larger than the generation just before them, Generation X. Millennials will soon be bringing to your property or dining room the greatest spending power of any generation to date.

Millennials are the first more or less completely “digitally native” generation. Their expectations as customers have been shaped by a lifetime of immersion in the fast-evolving worlds of online commerce, search engines, and on-the-go connectivity. These young people have always been exposed to cell phones, email, and the web. They’ve rarely waited in line at the bank or awaited the arrival of a letter by mail; GPS has kept them from ever needing to ask for directions or read a map; they’ve seldom had their musical choices limited to the radio or what can fit on a mass-marketed CD.

Customers in Every Generation are “Turning Millennial”

Millennials are important because of their sheer numbers and direct economic importance *and* because their preferences and behaviors are increasingly bleeding into the customer behavior of older generations. So it makes good economic sense to focus on millennial guest expectations both because their own purchasing power is valuable (and rapidly growing) and because their digitally driven expectations are spreading so quickly to other generations. The standard expectation of a seventeen-year-old or twenty-five-year-old guest today will be mirrored in the expectations of her mom and dad as well in a very, very short time.

Regardless of our age bracket, are well on our way to “becoming millennials” in terms of our service expectations. As Christopher Hunsberger of Four Seasons Hotels and Resorts puts it, “millennials are an important group of guests in their own right. But their significance is more than that. They’re a unique group in terms of their impact on the rest of our customer base. The behaviors and expectations of the millennial group tend to shape the thinking of the rest of us.”

Serving guests today and tomorrow means finding the best ways to streamline the hospitality experience via technology, and it means



delivering the warmest, most genuine human-to-human hospitality where such human interaction makes a difference. This isn't easy. Adapting your mindset to successfully serving new and rapidly evolving customers will take your attention, creativity, and hard work.

What Digital Has Done to Your Guests

Here's what the digital revolution has done to your guests. It might not be pretty, but it is (as annoying people annoyingly say) what it is. Customers now expect every business, in every industry, to achieve "digital parity," (a term I picked up from Jay Coldren at Marriott), meaning to be as easy to do business with as what customers have encountered in the very best online and self-service solutions.

- *Interactions should be intuitive, efficient, and fast, and shouldn't require unwanted, extraneous human intervention by either the customer or your employees.*

In a hospitality context, this means that guests expect a streamlined, seamless, technology supported experience. Shelley Meszoly, regional director of sales and marketing at Fairmont Southampton (Bermuda): "Your service needs to be easy to book, it needs to be easy to buy, it needs to be available through all their desired channels: on their phone, their iPad, or in person, with no glitches and no holdups. [Guests] expect everything they need to be in front of them, effortlessly available, entirely transparent, and ready to be used."

- *Customers should have control over their own account details, including the ability to modify their service preferences, and the service provider should have omni-channel access to this information as well.* In a hospitality context, this means, among other things, that guests

expect service providers to have access to the guest's entire customer history and guest preferences, without the guest needing to repeat or rekey any of it. This information should be (discreetly) available, with zero notice and no lag time, across properties and everywhere within a property, whether a guest is interacting with the employee in person, on the phone, over the Internet, or via mobile.⁴² It also means that guests are starting to expect functionality along the lines of the Hilton Hotels app's functionality that allows you to choose your own specific room, literally down to the room number (although, as of press time, without useful indicators such as "which rooms have connecting doors"), from available choices, or of the new Four Seasons app's ability to summon housekeeping from offsite—when a guest realizes they left their privacy light on back at the property but still want their room cleaned before they get back.

- *Service should move quickly, and time restrictions should be malleable, like they are online.* In a hospitality context, this means guests expect speedy service and flexible hours, just like they're used to online. (Think about it: when you're shopping online, you never have to wait in line to check out and pay. And online, a site is always open to serve you on your own schedule, with no waiting and no "sorry, we're closed.") For example, guests are starting to expect to be able to order during the interval *between* the lunch and dinner hours—and to be able to order an item from the lunch menu during the dinner hour, and vice versa. It means that for room service to be relevant, it needs to get faster, perhaps *twice* as fast, à la Four Seasons' recently rolled out fifteen-minute room

service promise. It means, in the foodservice context, that the variety of innovative tabletop tech solutions that allow guests to pay their bills without flagging a waiter or waiting for that waiter to run to the POS (point of sale device) to charge a guest's card are steps in the right direction, assuming that they're implemented with sensitivity.

This is a tough, hard-nosed set of expectations that guests are beginning to bring to your doorstep, and the industry needs to adapt to them, and soon.

Checking Out the Check-In Situation

Let's look at check-in, which offers in microcosm the issues that need to be resolved as we move into the future as an industry. Hoteliers have traditionally conceived of check-in as an important moment for high-touch service, rather than as a merely transactional function. They put great stock in finding ways to ensure that the check-in experience is personal and memorable. I, too, am in favor of these hospitable goals; the trouble comes when these goals are pursued at the expense of speed and efficiency, and without giving guests any choice in the matter. Modern hotel guests will inevitably compare the slow, benevolently authoritarian hotel check-in process with what they recently experienced via online booking and air travel, the systems that have allowed them to choose their exact preferred schedule and seat, make meal and special needs requests, and print out a boarding pass, all from the comfort of home.

This is the process, in fact, that has conveyed them to the front desk of the hotel, where they're now waiting grudgingly in line. And they'll likely find the contrast a bit absurd.

Stand in line. Wait for a front desk agent. Orally deliver intricate, intimate information to the agent. Watch him slowly and approximately enter this data on a DOS era computer terminal—the same data that an average consumer has used for online service transactions six times

that same day. Allow the clerk to choose a room, based on only nominal knowledge of the guest's preferences. Wait to be handed a room key, at which juncture the clerk, in a suddenly resonant voice, asks that indiscreet question: "How many keys would you like, Ms. _____ [last-name-I'm-going-to-say-particularly-loud-in-case-somebody-in-the-lobby-wants-to-know-if-you're-expecting-a-visitor]?" Finally, listen to the agent's canned recitation of the hotel's unique features. All before being finally liberated to go about your business.

Hotels would do well to find a way to resolve the check-in conundrum—and some of them are. Hilton, Marriott, Starwood, and Fairmont have recently implemented smartphone based check-in solutions. CitizenM, a stylish limited-service hotel chain in Europe, has entirely eliminated the front desk, replacing it with a bank of self-service check-in kiosks similar to those found in airports. Unlike your average airport, however, CitizenM has a cadre of truly engaging employees working the lobby: "Hi, and welcome. Have you been to CitizenM before? First time? Great, let me help you check in."

Although the employee offers to handle the check-in himself, he also indicates to the guest that the self-service approach is really a snap. True to his word, the kiosk technology is great. Typing in the first few characters of the guest's last name brings up the reservation details. Payment is confirmed with a swipe of the card, and instructions on the screen direct the guest to a box of blank key cards on the counter in front of the kiosk. Tapping on the screen encodes the keycard and a separate receipt pops out with the room number printed on it. All the while, the smartly dressed and eager staff members are nearby and available to help. Fast, efficient, and friendly.



HOW'S THAT SMARTPHONE-AS-ROOM-KEY COMING?

Hilton made a bit of a splash some time back with its announcement that guest smartphones would soon function as room keys, and promising an aggressive schedule for the rollout. As it has turned out, this smartphone-as-room-key rollout has been slow going, both at Hilton and at its competitors. While some Hilton (and some Starwood, Marriott, and independent properties) have indeed launched the technology, simple economics are for the time being holding back a more widespread implementation.

The cost *per door* to retrofit a hotel with the smartphone-as-room-key is three hundred to five hundred dollars, a hard sell to make to a property owner, who for a 200-room hotel would have to go out and spend \$60,000 to \$100,000. On the other hand, any hotel property that's already fitted with "wave keycard to open" NFC functionality—or the "wave your wristband" approach of Great Wolf Lodge—can be refitted less expensively to being smartphone-enabled.

Not for Everyone

But the CitizenM model isn't to everyone's taste, nor is it right for every service environment. Says luxury hotelier Mark Harmon, chairman of Auberge Resorts: "I think the kiosk can come off as offensive, especially when you're paying a few more bucks for your room," as Harmon coyly understates it; a night at an Auberge property can easily reach the four digits. "I certainly share the goal of off-loading transactional details, just not forcibly off-loading them onto the guest."

Harmon prefers to "use a roving iPad to check people in without ever making them wait in line—and [hoteliers should] reconsider if they even need to make guests go through check-in at all. At Auberge, we often

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(click to watch author's video)

know our guests and their expected arrival ahead of time, and can welcome them and hand them their keys directly,” without either cattle-call queuing or making guests perform the check-in work themselves.

When guests arrive at the David Rockwell-designed Nobu Hotel in Las Vegas, they’re greeted by a concierge who takes them to their room via a dedicated elevator for a private in-room iPad registration. And at the Andaz in Maui, another design from David Rockwell replaces the standard single check-in desk. Rockwell describes it: “Cozy groupings of furniture provide a more welcoming and personal experience: Each individual check-in desk features different, unique touches, such as telescopes or sandpits.” (I have to wonder how they ever got buy-in from housekeeping for *intentionally* bringing sand into the lobby for guests to track through the hotel!)

Whatever streamlining solution is applied to the check-in experience, once it is instituted, the job duties of the lobby staff can be redefined. While one staffer handles check-in, another can show guests around the lobby and explain the offerings and hours of the hotel’s café and bar. A third can draw a map to a nearby museum or help guests hail a cab. The staff can focus, in other words, on making the guest experience better and more meaningful, instead of on queue control and laborious data entry.

Where Do Humans Fit in the Service Equation?

Building the right experience for today’s customers requires you to think hard about an uncomfortable subject: where human employees are helpful to customers, and where they just get in the way.

Today’s customers often *do* want you out of the way. Younger customers, in particular, hold different ideas about where human-powered service fits into the customer experience. Through years of experience with online and self-service solutions, they’ve grown used to the way technology can reduce the need for human gatekeepers to ensure accuracy and manage data. So the last thing they want is for your employees to gum up the works without adding value.

Think for a moment about how many transactions customers today routinely conduct without any human interaction. They make dinner reservations, sign up for classes, review schoolwork and grades, schedule and reschedule medical appointments. Previously, all these transactions required contact with another human. Now, thanks to technological advances, they can often be carried out without uttering a word to a single employee. In handling such transactions without the intervention of employees, customers have discovered that technology often takes care of such logistical functions faster and more capably than when employees insert themselves into the equation.

Meet the Jetsons

One of my secrets for creating a superior experience for today's customers is my (unauthorized) Jetsons' Approach to Customer Service, based on the 1962 television series set a hundred years in the future. It's a colorful little test you can use to determine the service functions that belong on either side of the human/technology divide—that is, which services you should off-load to technology and which ones you should keep in the hands of your employees.

Here's what customer service looks like in the Jetsons' vision of the future:

- ***Much of the customer service is provided by machines.***

And much of this machine-based service is actually self-service: ordering breakfast from an automated menu at home, recording telephone messages on rewriteable LP records. (They got this prediction at least 75 percent right.) And, of course, housecleaning via Rosie the Robot, the animatronic housekeeper with a New Yawk accent and an attitude to match. (Hilton Hotels is currently testing its answer to Rosie: a robot assistant cutely named for the brand's founder, Conrad Hilton. Powered by IBM Watson artificial intelligence, Connie is currently in residence

at the Hilton McLean, Virginia, right in the heart of the D.C. sprawlosphere. And in a West Coast nod to Rosie, Aloft Cupertino Hotel in the heart of Silicon Valley recently deployed a personable little robot dubbed Botlr that can come to your floor—summoning the elevator for itself—to assist you with little items you need and such.)

- *The service provided by humans adds what people want out of human interaction: warmth and a little drama.* Consider the friendly southern accented receptionist who provides a warm greeting at the factory where George Jetson works, or consider Henry, the apartment building's superintendent who does a bit of handiwork here and there but whose primary function is to be buddies with the Jetson family.

This is a pretty solid model for dividing your operations. If a person can do the job better—meaning more flexibly, accurately, creatively, dramatically, or simply more pleasantly—assign that task to the warm-blooded. Otherwise, if the task/touchpoint is something that automation or computers with algorithms can handle better, be sure to offer self-service, “my account,” or app-based functionality as at least an option for your customers.

The exceptions are when warmth comes at the expense of efficiency, or vice versa. Then, it's a judgment call. And there will be *many* judgment calls; don't get me wrong. Just one fascinating example of this, where human inefficiency has been found to be preferable, is Air New Zealand's business class plane interiors that are *intentionally* designed to require human intervention (turndown) at bedtime from a skilled flight attendant. While other business class carriers have seats designed to change fully automatically to and from a sleeping position, Air New Zealand decided this was a mistake because the turndown part of their service, while technically not necessary, was crucial to the passenger experience.

The futuristic Jetsonian approach, however, can be a magnet for mischief. Once you've saved resources by automating tasks and services, it's tempting to pocket the savings and call it a day. But improving automated customer service is no excuse to offer lousy human-powered service. Instead, take the resources recouped through digitization and focus them on meaningful human interactions in the places where they count.



WHERE TABLET-BASED ORDERING AND HUMAN WARMTH COEXIST

If you bring tablet-based ordering to your restaurant, be sure you think out what you're doing, and be especially sure your waitstaff doesn't use it, consciously or unconsciously, as an excuse to offer slacker "why don't you look at the tablet already?" service. Believe me, this is a very big danger. A renowned chain of steakhouses in the Midwest—that will remain nameless—has switched recently to an iPad-based menu, and the answer to any question you might ask a server is responded to exactly thus: "you can read all about it on the tablet."

By contrast, if you're looking for a restaurant to benchmark that has a well-thought-out, Jetsonian hybrid approach—human warmth *and* automated service—consider looking at Colorado Springs' Natural Epicurean, located on the campus of the Broadmoor. Particularly popular with young families, as well as singles and couples in their late teens and twenties, Natural Epicurean is a restaurant devoted to natural foods that fit a variety of diets and food restrictions. In pursuit of this goal, The Natural Epicurean offers its guests the option of using a tablet-based menu to assist them with their dining choices. The tablet menu allows guests to:

- Select a meal based on food restrictions or dietary requirements (for example, select "desserts under four hundred calories" and you see what is available)

- Browse every menu on the item to see very specific information (calorie count, sodium content, etc.) about any items that are catching your eye
- Allow you to consider substitutions for item ingredients and to see the resulting difference in nutritional value

But here's the difference at The Natural Epicurean: Not only is the technology spiffy, but the waitstaff clearly doesn't consider it a replacement for the service—the warmth, recognition, and flexibility—that they as humans are so well qualified to provide.

At no point did I feel pressure from my waitress to figure everything out for myself electronically. The tablet was merely an adjunct, to save a customer with dietary restrictions from having to awkwardly ask question after question while nailing down choices (and perhaps to prevent the ridiculous ad libs waiters sometimes are forced to make when asked complex nutritional and ingredient-related questions on the fly).

The waitress was there for when questions came up that the tablet could not have been prepared to answer, such as my eleven-year-old son asking for help finding “the least healthy item on the menu.” While she didn't oblige with a direct answer, she did clarify that the “ancient grains” bun on the bison burger could be swapped out for a white one, and the pesto on the burger replaced with American cheese (excuse me a moment while I hang my head in parental shame).

A large study of the hospitality industry recently by J. D. Power confirmed the importance of retaining human-delivered service touches, even as automation comes to the fore. Specifically, Power found that the *number* of employees with whom guests interact affects their overall satisfaction. Customers who interact more often with service staff, and with a broader cross-section of that staff, reported greater satisfaction. (The highest satisfaction was reported by guests who were served by four or more types of employees and the lowest by those who received

no further service beyond front desk check-in.) “As hoteliers experiment with automated methods of check-in and check-out that tend to reduce the number of human touchpoints, it is important that they use the additional staff time gained to offer a warmer, more personalized experience for their guests,” says Ramez Faza, senior manager of the global travel and hospitality practice at J. D. Power. “Hotels should never underestimate the power of the human element. Whether it’s assisting a guest with a special request or a friendly greeting from staff members in the hallway, the people aspect plays a key role in guest satisfaction and loyalty.”⁴³

So, the name of the game is to take any savings you realize from automating transactional details and invest them in the live performance aspect of your business. I fear, though, that this is a game that few are going to play. Instead, as the airlines have done before them, shortsighted hospitality operators will pass the automation-driven savings along to their shareholders and consider themselves done. The problem with this approach is that it removes your differentiation, which is a recipe, ultimately, to put yourself out of business. Because if all you can offer is streamlining, what’s left to distinguish the service experience in the minds and memories of your customers?

“Only great customer service allows you the ‘price elasticity’ that supports your bottom line so you can survive in this business,” cautions Tom Colicchio. “I appreciate the pressure to reduce employees through technology, especially with the minimum wage going up, but if technology is deployed for that reason alone, it’s a recipe for failure. Success in this business is not about that, it’s about creating such a great offering that you can actually have some elasticity in pricing, because you are providing such a good experience. If you’re cutting corners or substituting technology just to save money, it cuts out your competitive edge; your offerings will become the same as everyone else and your pricing will have to be as well. The only way you can move out of this trap, the value add that’s going to get you there, is service and hospitality.”



Full-Service Hotels: A Particular Kind of Magic Trick

A hotel, especially a full-service hotel, is a particular kind of a magic trick. It's the transformation of what by rights should be a commodity—chairs, table, a bed, a toilet that flushes properly—into something else: a place where lodgers become guests, where relationships are refreshed, where memories are created.

Superior hotels have long accomplished this with service personally delivered by exquisitely trained humans who remember guest names, who are alert to mood changes in guests, who strive to serve not only what a guest directly asks for, but what the guest may not even know that they're looking for.

The Luxury-Mobile Paradox

Fitting mobile, automated, and self-service offerings into this human-driven hospitality scenario is touchy. There's more, it would seem, that can go wrong than can go right, a reality that has deterred full-service—especially luxury—lodging brands from rushing in. While some Five Star hotels have made at least the partial leap (ultra-luxury Auberge Resorts has been offering iPad-based room service ordering for some time, as has Aria, the 4,004-room luxury behemoth in Las Vegas), the dominant sentiment has been “watch and wait.”

But that's changing, with Ritz-Carlton hotels being the first out of the gate in mobilizing, so to speak, the luxury experience for its guests. (Not long afterward, The Ritz-Carlton's estimable competitor, Four Seasons Hotels and Resorts, rolled out its own intriguing app experience.) The Ritz-Carlton mobile experience includes poolside ordering, mobile room service, app-based service requests (replacing that toothbrush you accidentally discarded, the extra washcloth, soaps, or shoeshine touch-up you need before dinner), real-time device-agnostic folio review, mobile check-in, mobile check-out, and the nifty “shareable experiences” feature that I covered in chapter 8.

Mobile Check-in

Mobile check-in at The Ritz-Carlton starts with providing the guest with a personalized one-click link the day before arrival. Enter your anticipated arrival time and phone number, and at the appropriate time you'll get an SMS message to confirm that your room is ready, at which point you go to "mobile check-in" to pick up your keys. No further registration or identification is needed, unless required by law, and no additional credit card swipe.

The thing is, this being The Ritz-Carlton, the current front desk scenario, without all this new mobile check-in functionality, is hardly a hardship. The odds of having to wait in line for a surly, distracted, gum-chewing front desk clerk at The Ritz-Carlton or one of its estimable competitors is less likely than a direct lightning strike penetrating an underground bunker.

So what *does* mobile check-in buy you as a luxury hotel guest? It offers various functionality that travelers (including, The Ritz-Carlton tells me, the luxury travelers with whom they've spent two years researching and planning this app) appreciate. It allows these guests to handle their transactional details themselves, on a self-service basis, checking that everything is just as they want it (no more "is the card I have on file the one you want to use?" kind of gentle runaround, no more mistyping of hard to spell guest names, no more inability to double-check reservation details on your own). Thus giving the guest a more comfortable feeling of being both in the moment and in control.

Poolside Ordering

Now, picture this. You're poolside at The Ritz-Carlton. You can't track down one of their Ladies or Gentlemen, so you have to trudge all the way (twenty yards) to the pool bar, order your drink, and tote that tonic and gin all the way back to your poolside chair or cabana.

Tough, isn't it? It's also unlikely. The reality is, this "my kingdom for a waiter's attention" scenario is an unlikely one at a Ritz-Carlton or one of its worthy competitors. Rather, as I've discussed earlier, their employees are meticulously trained to recognize the most subtle eye contact or nod of a head, and come over to assist you before you need to ask for a thing or move a muscle.

So what, exactly, in this scenario would make a guest think they need the assistance of an app? It's more a question of guest preference than need. Sometimes, guests prefer to have a self-service experience, an experience that conforms to what they've gotten used to in the rest of their device-driven life. Not necessarily all of the time, but during those times when they don't want to interact (or interact before they're ready) with a human employee, when they want to browse available options within the privacy of their own skull, when they want a feeling of direct, self-service, DIY control.

The Future Is Now: How Ivy Uses IBM's Watson to Provide Artificial Intelligence-Driven Hospitality

There are some hotels that are already embracing the Jetsonian future, assigning less mission-critical tasks to automation while retaining the most sensitive tasks for handling by human employees.

One comprehensive approach to offering an on-site alternative to human intervention is Ivy, an artificial intelligence-driven system capable of handling, in real time, some 90 percent (according to its parent company, Go Moment) of the requests that come in from guests on property, without requiring a lick of human intervention.

Ivy is powered by IBM's Watson, the world-famous, Jeopardy-winning artificial intelligence (AI, also referred to as Cognitive) engine. Ivy uses this Watson engine to decipher and fulfill a wide variety of requests from hotel guests in real time.

Ivy is the brainchild of Raj Singh, President and CEO of its parent company, Go Moment. Singh is both a technologist and a kid-emeritus

who grew up working hands-on in his family's hotels. Coming from this hospitality background, Singh tells me, made him aware of the detailed knowledge that would be required to ever automate the challenges that come up in hospitality, and the nuanced approach that would be required to do so in a manner that would draw guests closer to a hospitality brand rather than putting them off with a stilted, tone-deaf set of responses.

To pull this off, Singh knew he would need some powerful help. So when he heard that IBM had allocated \$100 million for venture investments to support startups and businesses committed to leading a specific industry with cognitive applications powered by Watson, he jumped at the opportunity.

The resulting Watson-Ivy collaboration plays out as follows, starting at check-in, where the hotel's (human) front desk attendant asks the guest if they'd be willing to opt in to the Ivy system. If you opt in, says Singh, "you get a little welcome message when you get to your room that says, 'Micah, welcome to the W Los Angeles. How do you like your room so far?' You can reply, 'five stars, I love the view. Can I get a bottle of red wine? And I could use a few more hand towels.' Each request will be interpreted and dispatched to the correct department automatically using Watson categorization."

You can also—and these colorful examples are obviously mine, not Singh's—text "Wassup, People?! I asked for a king and got to my room and there's two queen beds instead" or "If I had a burning desire to have my ear as close as possible to the ice machine, I would have indicated that when I checked in. Now can I please have a quieter room?" and Ivy will reply "I'm very sorry to hear that; a bellman will soon be at your door to take you to the correct room." (Note: If you say "I freaking hate this place; beam me out of here," or otherwise express any kind of upset, Ivy bows out and a human is immediately dispatched, as I'll discuss below.)

Ivy is frequently called on to deliver instant answers to knowledge-based questions. For example, if a guest texts 'what is the WiFi password?,' it will deliver an answer instantly, with no humans needing to be

involved. And when the “reply” needed is a task rather than information, that’s in Ivy’s skill set as well. In the example of asking for extra hand towels, Watson is able to route that request directly to the laundry for faster and better results. “That’s what the Ivy platform does: It streamlines operations and automates most decisions that previously required distracting the front desk from the guest waiting to check in.” This way, says Singh, “the guest is always the center of attention and always has all of the hotel’s resources at their disposal. Now your request goes directly to the right department in a fraction of the time it would take the front desk to manually receive, log, and relay your request.”

(Watson, you may remember, is essentially a “question-answering engine,” initially developed by IBM to be able to decode the many ways a question can be asked on Jeopardy in essentially zero time—and get to that buzzer first! The answers, in other words, are not really the trick to Watson; any encyclopedia can do that part of the trick. It’s the *questions* that matter. So while it might not seem like all of Watson’s smarts are required to answer something like “What’s the Wifi passcode?” the power of Watson is really coming in to play here to decode the many, many ways that a guest might make such a request. Fifteen different people might ask for the same thing in fifteen different ways: “What’s the wireless passcode?” “How do I get on the internet? And so forth. Watson’s involvement here is in detecting the intention behind the words. This keeps things effortless for the guest with Watson allowing the Ivy text responses to adapt to the guest, rather than the other way around.

Creating Ivy has required its creators to get down and dirty with the particular issues that come up at each particular client hotel. In doing so, they’ve found that there are about 1,400 issues that can come up, barring an outlier event such as a fire. According to Singh, more than half of these don’t require human judgment on the other side, and that half account for a significant majority of the interactions that come up.

Of course, the issues that *don’t* make up this “significant majority not requiring human judgment” should be of great concern to anyone

considering deploying such a system. Because here's the rub: If an organization blows it on the items that do require true service recovery, it just doesn't matter how many mundane issues were correctly handled; that latter, emotionally-charged failure is what customers are going to remember.

So a concern I had when exploring Ivy—and that you should have before laying down your money for such a system—was whether Ivy's ability to answer the somewhat mundane majority of what comes up would cause its developers to develop hubris and inappropriately deploy Ivy to try to act as if she/he were human, with potentially guest-alienating results. So I wanted to find out how, and whether, “she” knows to escalate the texts received that require or would benefit from a human response.

Here, I've been so far reassured by the logic behind Ivy. Ivy is programmed to escalate any expressions of dissatisfaction to humans. According to Singh, “The first question that Ivy always asks the guest is ‘How's everything going?’ If any negative words are detected in that response or if the person says, one star, my sheets are dirty, my toilet's overflowing, and all those kind of common issues—we've got hundreds of them cataloged for every single hotel that is on our portfolio—we escalate any negative experiences from the customer instantly to the front desk and then track how quickly the desk agent follows up with them. So let's say you express that you're having a bad experience. Let's say you type ‘my sheets are dirty.’ Ivy knows what all of us in the hospitality business know: that ‘dirty’ is a really bad word. So we send that off to the front desk for personal attention. From the time the staff gets a text message and email alert, they usually have twenty minutes to resolve the issue before Ivy escalates the issue to the general manager.”

(Ivy will also dispatch a human when Watson isn't entirely confident that it understands the meaning of a question or how to resolve it; for example, if a guest says something like “my internet is broken.” From this, Ivy can detect that the guest is talking about the Internet, but doesn't have a way of resolving this issue of the Internet being broken, because



Watson may not be able to understand what ‘broken’ means in that context. In such a case, Singh says, “Ivy turns to an algorithm to determine whether or not it should be dispatched to a human.”)

***Taking the Guest's Emotional Temperature in Real Time
(and Before They Get on TripAdvisor!)***

One promising way to think of a system such as Ivy is as “real-time satisfaction monitoring.” (Or, if you prefer, think of it as “pre-TripAdvisor satisfaction monitoring.”) Either way, it’s a powerful concept. You can think of it as having a sensor attached to every single guest that blinks red every time there’s a bad experience—so you know the right way to take care of it. It’s a lot less spooky for a hotelier this way. Previously, that in-room experience was pretty opaque. You know everyone’s in their rooms, but you don’t know how they’re feeling; you end up waiting ‘til checkout to ask for the guest’s feedback—and the response rate you receive is in the dismal, 2–3 percent range. (And by the time a staffer reviews this feedback, the guest is gone and may be publicly sharing their experience on social media.)

A system like Ivy, on the other hand, is designed to give hoteliers ten times as much feedback, and get it to them a whole lot earlier: a hotel will get feedback from 30 percent of their guests in as little as twenty minutes after check-in. So if the guest encountered dirty sheets, Ivy can alert staff in real-time and give you a better chance of ensuring that every guest leaves with a smile on their face—a long time before they ever get to TripAdvisor and have the chance (and inclination) to skewer you publicly. In fact, Go Moment provided me with data (I have not verified this, so take it for what it’s worth) suggesting that Ivy has assisted one of its clients, The Declan Suites San Diego, in rising thirty-five ranks on TripAdvisor—an increase in TripAdvisor visibility similar to what you’d expect from undertaking a multi-million dollar renovation.



THE SECRET OF SUCCESSFUL IN-ROOM TECHNOLOGY: SIMPLICITY

Don't make the mistake of thinking that because guests today are so familiar with technology, it's okay to throw clunky technology with complex interfaces at them and expect patience or understanding as customers struggle to find a workaround. The reality of customers today, especially younger customers, of what they will accept is quite the opposite, because the technology encountered elsewhere in their lives has itself become so much more user-friendly than what previous generations encountered. The relentless focus on simplifying the user interface at Apple, Amazon, Google, and other less visible technology players has set a standard of intuitiveness across the tech industry that customers today, especially Millennials, accept as the norm. As technology and marketing professional J. D. Peterson puts it, "Millennials simply expect technology to work, and to work reliably, with a minimum of complexity"⁴⁴ because that's been their experience with the technology that has been at their disposal during their lifetimes.

Therefore, installing complicated in-room remotes, or offering confusing, complex options on in-room thermostats, is exactly the wrong approach here. For climate control, two settings are adequate: + and -. If you install mechanized drapes and shades, they should have at most four settings: open, closed (for the drapes), up, down (for the shades). (And, as far as in-room telephone options, emulate Virgin Hotels in chapter 4 and their single "yes!" button for any kind of service a guest may be looking for.)

The (Increasing) Need for Speed

As I mentioned at the start of this chapter, what your guests expect in terms of speed is growing more extreme every day, accelerating with the pace of technological development. Faster Internet speeds, increased access to the web, the proliferation of smartphones and tablets, intuitive

search functions, and always-on GPS are some of the developments that influence the timeliness expectations that customers have. Millennials in particular place a premium on speed and convenience. They're twice as likely as other customers to buy their groceries at convenience stores (in spite of convenience stores' wild markups), and they disproportionately patronize fast-casual options like Panera and Pei Wei, as well as prepackaged to-go food options—all of which allow them to avoid the waiting-around-for-waitstaff routine.⁴⁵ But young customers are merely the most visible front for these changes. Customers of all ages now expect speedier service, in part because successful brands, both upstarts and established players, have shown that it's possible to speed up service without sacrificing quality. This new norm creates a risk for any business that fails to keep up with the accelerated timetable that customers demand.

Avoiding the Cliff of Dissatisfaction

One concept to keep in mind as you revamp your operation in the interest of speed is “the cliff of dissatisfaction.” This is the point at which a customer loses faith in the timeliness of your company or your product. The length of time it takes a customer to reach the cliff varies from business to business, but it's a risk inherent in every service interaction and business relationship.

A time-aware business needs to actively strive to keep customers safely away from this precipice. Starbucks knows how long an average customer will wait, from acknowledgement (“Can I get something started for you?”) to receipt of a finished, customized drink. Starbucks dresses its stores with clever merchandising and appealing decor to make these minutes pass as pleasantly as possible, but it also understands that, ultimately, too long is still not good enough. When “too long” threatens, countermeasures are taken. For example, baristas will venture out from behind the counter and take orders from people who haven't yet reached the counter. Starbucks ultimately lets the cliff of dissatisfaction guide its business expansion. As soon as the company's metrics indicate that the

level of demand and the resulting wait times are routinely threatening customer satisfaction, Starbucks opens another store down the block.

Casino management is a highly scientific discipline that leaves the gambling solely to its customers. The team at Caesars Entertainment knows how long the average gambler will wait for a complimentary drink on the casino floor before he gets fed up. They know within how many minutes after arrival a casino guest needs to be greeted before he'll wander elsewhere, as well as how many minutes can elapse between subsequent service touches and free drinks without him moving on. Caesars doesn't rely on intuition to guide how it staffs the casino floors; it turns to staff tracking and other data for help, including the RFID tags I first mention in chapter 2 that allow them to scan the waitstaff's entry and exit of the bar area. This allows managers to track the time a server takes to sweep her section and return to the bar for her customers' orders, data that the casino uses to improve its decisions about staffing and flow.

Want to Outfox Your Competitors? Compress Time

Two hospitals with Midwestern origins, Mayo Clinic and Cleveland Clinic, have become world famous for their innovative approaches to health care. Both hospitals have succeeded in part by challenging the traditional (read *slow*) model of medicine. At the Mayo Clinic, patients fly in from all over the world for "efficient, time-compressed care that can usually provide a definitive diagnosis and sometimes initial treatment, including major surgery, within three to five days," as ⁴⁶Leonard L. Berry and Kent D. Seltman, authors of *Management Lessons from Cleveland Clinic*, put it.

Mayo refuses to settle for the sluggish, unreliable timeline common in hospitals today. Just one way that Mayo sets itself apart is in its approach to reading scans, such as mammograms. Less time-sensitive hospitals put all scans, whether taken early in the day or late in the afternoon, into a slowly filling holding "basket," then wait until the evening to analyze and interpret them. This means a patient may be called a day later and asked to suffer through a redo (and another torturous round of waiting) if a

technical issue arises with the initial scan. Compare this to the procedure at Mayo, where scans are read more or less on the spot, allowing them to be verified while doctors are still at the patient's side.⁴⁷

Ohio-based Cleveland Clinic's own focus on timeliness has helped it improve its overall reputation for patient sensitivity. By working to match or even exceed the scheduling expectations of its patients, it has improved its patient satisfaction scores from among the lowest 10 percent of the nation to now rank among the world's highest.

Cleveland Clinic achieved this remarkable transformation by working backward, setting "unrealistic" speed goals and then getting to work figuring out how they could be achieved. For example, they had this gutsy goal: They decided that anybody calling the Cleveland Clinic for an appointment (with any complaint and for any specialty) would be seen that same day. Cleveland Clinic's success in pulling this off is quite an accomplishment when you consider it in contrast to the month-long waits some specialists demand their patients endure.

You can test this yourself, if you're so inclined. Call Cleveland Clinic on the phone today and you'll hear a mind-blowing greeting: "Thank you for calling Cleveland Clinic. Would you like to be seen today?" Only after 4:00 p.m. does the greeting roll over to "Would you like to be seen tomorrow?"

Pulling off the same-day appointment feat has been far from easy. The effort at Cleveland Clinic had to clear some high hurdles. Dr. James Merlino, who headed Patient Experience for Cleveland Clinic at the time, says that an extraordinary amount of time and effort are devoted to "managing the flow and ensuring we have the capacity."

This commitment to speed comes in part from Cleveland Clinic's awareness of the growing number of millennial patients it sees and whom it expects to see more of as they age and start families of their own. As Dr. Merlino told me, "Nobody of any age wants to wait, but we understand that the expectations of the millennial generation are especially accelerated, and this has certainly affected our thinking."

Fifteen-Minute Room Service

Not long ago, a Four Seasons property in Boston came up with, and successfully rolled out, hotel-wide fifteen-minute room service. The standard prior, and throughout the industry still, is a thirty to forty-minute wait. In Four Seasons' way of thinking, the prospect of such long wait times was essentially making a significant cohort of today's time-sensitive guests not even consider room service as a viable dining option. "Room service, generally speaking, is not something you think of as being quick," Christopher Hunsberger from Four Seasons told me. "But millennials and business travelers in general want 'quick,' and we realized that the industry's traditional conception of how long is acceptable for a room service delivery time was losing us business."

The Boston Four Seasons came up with the idea, piloted it, and subsequently shared it with corporate headquarters, who have rolled it out at other properties as well. "While it's a simple idea in theory, it's not simple to execute; it requires multiple stakeholders in the organization to coordinate. At the property level, you're talking about the kitchen and room service staff being able to coordinate that and make it happen." But it has been worth it. The new fifteen-minute delivery promise has revamped and rejuvenated the concept of room service and made it attractive to today's guests.



Afterword

Farewell for Now, and Happy Hospitality!

We've covered a lot of ground here, and I hope you've enjoyed and benefited from the time you've spent reading my book.

One way to ensure you retain this material for your day-to-day use is to review each of the "And Your Point Is?" summaries at the end of the chapters whenever you need a refresher.

You can reach me directly to discuss applying these insights more specifically to your situation at micah@micahsolomon.com or (484)343-5881. I wish you happiness in your hospitality endeavors!

“AND YOUR POINT IS?”***Key Points from Chapter 9: How the Digital Revolution Has Changed Your Customers***

- ▶ Customers expect every business in every industry to achieve “digital parity.” You need to be able to offer all the advantages, and be as easy to do business with, as the best of what your customer has encountered online and in self-service solutions.
- ▶ Interactions should be intuitive, efficient, and fast, and shouldn’t require unwanted, extraneous human intervention by either the customer or your employees.
- ▶ Your processes should provide your customers with control over their own account details, including the ability to modify their service preferences. You, the service provider, should have cross-channel access to this information as well.
- ▶ Time should be speedy and malleable, like it is online.
- ▶ These changes in expectations are most completely realized in the newest generation of guests, the digitally native millennial generation. But change has also come to their elders, customers who aren’t millennials but have been influenced by a millennial outlook.
- ▶ Consider the “Jetsons Test” for deciding which service tasks should be off-loaded to automation vs what service should be delivered by humans. If a human can do the job more efficiently or effectively than a machine can, then a human should be doing it. If a person can do the job more *warmly* than a machine, assign that task as well to a person. Otherwise, leave it to the machines.
- ▶ Improving automated customer service is no excuse to offer lousy human-powered service. Instead, take the resources recouped through digitization and focus them on meaningful human interactions in the places where they count.

- ▶ Technology, including in-room technology, websites, apps, etc., should be simple and easy to use. Don't make the mistake of thinking that because guests today are familiar with using technology, it's okay to throw clunky, complex technology at them and expect customers to patiently struggle to find a workaround.
- ▶ Hospitality guests—along with customers in all industries—are increasing their demands for speedy service. Anything you can do to improve your speed of service and/or the extent to which your service matches the timetables of your guests will be appreciated.



About the Author



MICAH SOLOMON is one of the world's leading authorities on customer service, the customer experience, consumer trends, hospitality, and company culture. He is a consultant, keynote speaker, trainer, and training designer specializing in these subjects, as well as being a best-selling author. His books have been translated into more than a half-dozen languages and are the recipients of multiple awards. Micah is a regular contributor to Forbes.com on the subjects of customer service and hospitality, and his expertise has been featured in *Inc. Magazine*, *Bloomberg BusinessWeek*, ABC, CBS, NBC, and the *Harvard Business Review*.

A business leader and entrepreneur himself, Micah built his own company into a market leader in the manufacturing and independent entertainment field, and he was also an early investor in the technology behind Apple's Siri.

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(click to watch author's video)

The Heart of Hospitality is a hospitality management resource like no other, created by leading customer service expert Micah Solomon and filled with exclusive, insider knowledge from the top professionals in the industry.

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- **Ritz-Carlton Hotel Company President and COO Herve Humler:** How to engage today's new breed of luxury travelers.
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—Raul Leal, CEO, Virgin Hotels